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SINGLE sentence from Narendra Modi's address at the consecration ceremony of the Balak Ram idol at the brand-new Ram Mandir in Ayodhya summed up the epochal nature of the event. Choking with emotion, the prime minister said, "Our Ram Lalla will no longer live in a tent, he will now reside in his divine mandir." The imagery those words evoked—from a forlorn tent to a grand temple—encapsulated the century-old bloody struggle to build a mandir at what is believed to be the birthplace of one of the most revered deities of the Hindu pantheon. It was also emblematic of the cultural renaissance that the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) led by Modi and its mentor, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), hope to foster in India in the months and years ahead. Not to mention the emotional connect the event generated among India's Hindu majority, which experts say will boost the BJP's bid to win a third consecutive term with a clear majority in the general election to be held in the summer of 2024.

Modi, though, will remain the prime mover, conductor and main *yajman* (patron) of this spectacular demonstration of Hindu revival and resurgence. As is his wont, everything about this moment was choreographed to perfection. In his first term, the prime minister resisted immense pressure from RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat and the Sangh Parivar to issue an ordinance to build the temple without waiting for the Supreme Court judgment on the matter. The Supreme Court had been hearing the Ayodhya land title case filed by its appellants since 2010. These litigants had appealed against the Allahabad High Court verdict the same year to divide the 2.77 acres of disputed land three ways—two parts to Hindu organisations and one part to

THE AYODHYA SAGA

Behind the momentous consecration ceremony, there's a 500-year-long chequered history



1528

Babar's general Mir Baqi builds the Babri Masjid, apparently at the behest of the emperor. Locals believe it was built over a pre-existing Hindu structure

1856-57

Following a communal riot, a railing is set up around the mosque

1858

Nihang Sikhs storm into the mosque and perform rituals

1885

A Nirmohi Akhara monk files a plea in the district court seeking permission to build a temple outside the mosque. It's rejected

1949

An idol of Ram is installed in the mosque surreptitiously; Hindus begin offering prayers. Local Muslims protest; the city magistrate attaches the property but refrains from removing the idol

1950-1959

Three suits filed by Hindus asking for unrestricted 'darshan'

1961

The Sunni Waqf Board submits a claim for regaining possession of the mosque